

THE GIRAFFE

Camelopardalis



SIZE RANKING 18

BRIGHTEST STAR
Beta (β) 4.0

GENITIVE
Camelopardalis

ABBREVIATION Cam

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
December–May

FULLY VISIBLE
90°N–3°S



This dim constellation of the far northern sky, representing a giraffe, was introduced in the early 17th century on a celestial globe created by the Dutch astronomer Petrus Plancius (see panel, below). The giraffe's long neck can be visualized as stretching around the north celestial pole toward Ursa Minor and Draco.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The brightest star in the constellation, Beta (β) Camelopardalis, is a double star whose fainter companion can be seen with a small telescope or even powerful binoculars. South of Beta (β) is 11 and 12 Camelopardalis, a wide double star with components of 5th and 6th magnitudes.

Within the giraffe's hindquarters is NGC 1502, a small open star cluster visible through binoculars or a small telescope. Binoculars also show a long chain of faint stars called Kemble's Cascade, which lead away from NGC 1502 toward Cassiopeia. This star feature is named after Lucian Kemble, a Canadian amateur astronomer who first drew attention to it in the late 1970s. None of the stars, however, are actually related.

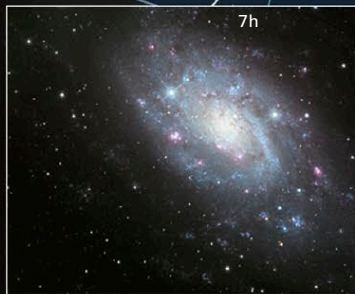
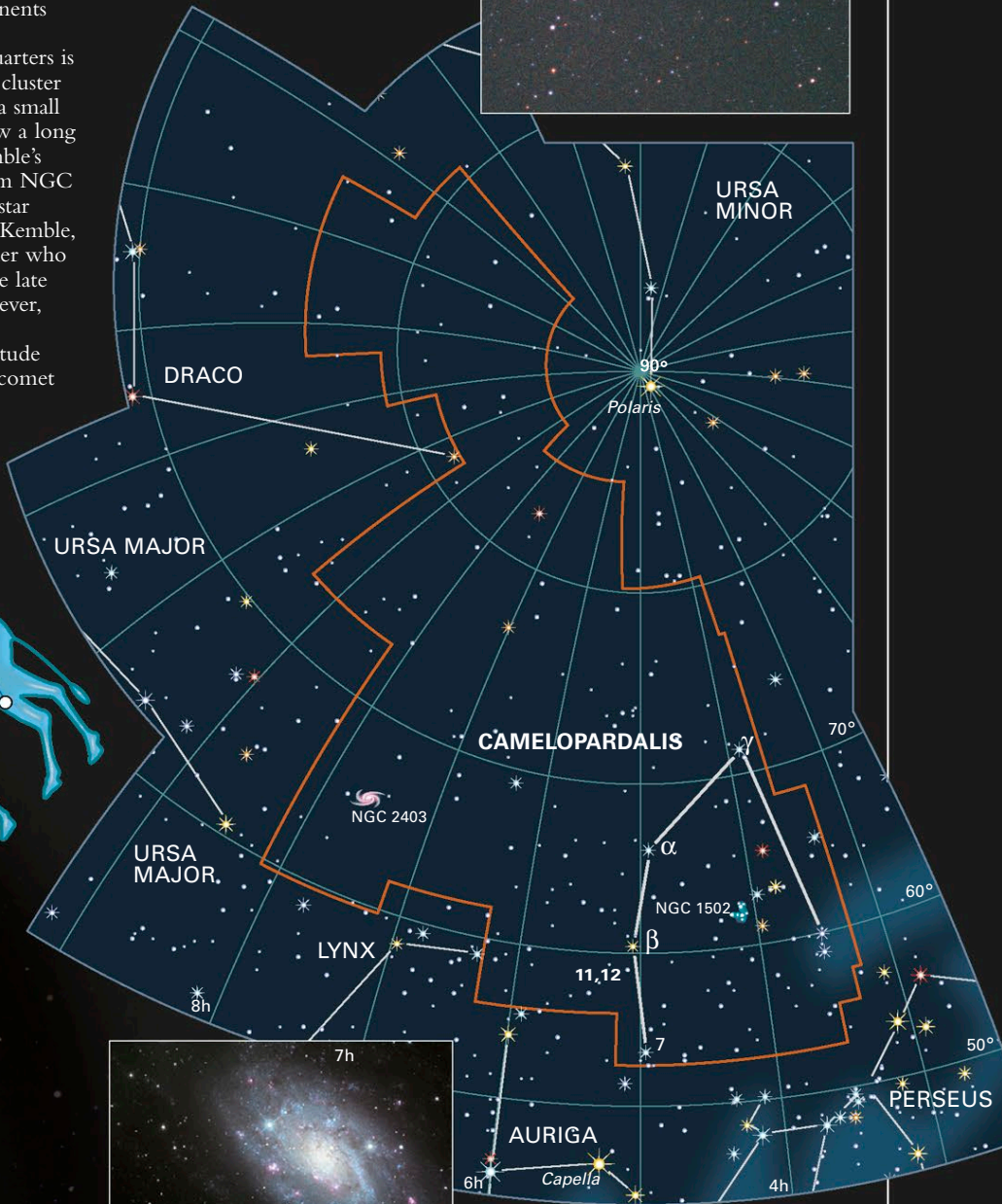
NGC 2403 is a 9th-magnitude spiral galaxy that looks like a comet when seen through a small telescope. It is one of the brightest and closest galaxies to the Earth, outside the Local Group.

KEMBLE'S CASCADE

In an area five times the diameter of a full moon, the stars of Kemble's Cascade seem to tumble down the sky. The small star cluster NGC 1502 can be seen in the lower left of the picture.



THE GIRAFFE



NGC 2403

Color images of this galaxy reveal the pink glow of large emission nebulae in its spiral arms. It is about 11 million light-years away.

PETRUS PLANCIUS

This Dutch church minister was also an expert geographer and astronomer. Petrus Plancius (1552–1622) taught the navigators on the first Dutch sea voyages to the East Indies how to measure star positions. In turn, they produced for him a catalog of the southern stars divided into 12 new constellations, which Plancius depicted on his celestial globes. He also invented several constellations, such as Columba, Camelopardalis, and Monoceros, using some of the fainter stars visible from Europe.



PARTIAL VIEW

It can be difficult to relate the figure of a giraffe to the stars of Camelopardalis. Here, the stars of the giraffe's legs are shown. The animal's long neck would stretch off the top of the picture.